

The trap that snares many business owners is the extreme opposite: *They look small and act big.*

“Joe Blow Enterprises.” Does this give you confidence that you are dealing with a strong, reputable company? This company name screams “This is a one-man show!” and says nothing substantial or attractive. Sorry, “Joe Blow Enterprises” is a monumental fail. I’m sure the logo is nonexistent, and, if there were one, it’d be bland, boring, or look like it was designed using some freeware paint program. This company’s Web site is static, stale, and childlike. No, Comic Sans doesn’t cut it for a professional image. This company sells to the world but doesn’t have a toll-free number. Small. Small. Small.

The problem compounds when their smallish business operates with biggish company actions. Call their business and you get a long maze of buttons to press only to land at the bottom of a voice mail dump. Send an email? Forget it. Most emails are ignored, and the ones read are answered weeks later. “I’ll get back to you” never happens. Customer service issues aren’t resolved in hours, but in weeks. If you insist on working 4 hours a week, your business won’t grow because your selfishness is more important than growing a business meteorically. Look small and act big and you dig your own potholes.

BEAT COMPETITORS BEFORE THEY START

My other purpose for “looking big” was to beat my competition before they even started. When someone (or some company) wants to set up shop and compete with you, they investigate you first. They look at your Web site, see what you’re doing and the prices you’re charging, and decide if they want to invest money and time to enter the space. To the untrained entrepreneur, a big company will scare would-be entrepreneurs almost like it scared me away . . . “Oh jeez, how can I compete when they have 12 employees against little me?”

If an entrepreneur thinks they can’t compete because you’re too big and too well-funded, you’ve won before they’ve even started. They either engage half-heartedly or defer to another industry with duller competition. *Look big, but act small.*

CHAPTER SUMMARY: FASTLANE DISTINCTIONS

- Complaints are valuable insights into your customers’ minds.
- Complaints of change are difficult to decipher and often require additional data to validate or invalidate.
- Complaints of expectation expose operational problems in either your business, or in your marketing strategy.
- Complaints of void expose unmet needs, raise the value of your product or service, and expose new revenue opportunities.
- Great customer service is as simple as violating your customer’s low expectation in the positive.